# Bayesian MCMC Validation of the Structural Self-Energy Expansion Framework (SSEE-V3.6):

Model Comparison against ΛCDM and CPL
using DESI DR2, Planck 2018, and Galaxy-Cluster Mass Data

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**Abstract**

We present a Bayesian validation of the dynamical sector of the Structural Self-Energy Expansion (SSEE-V3.6) framework [Almeida Vallejo, 2026] against DESI DR2 baryon acoustic oscillation data [Abdul-Karim et al., 2025], a compressed Planck 2018 prior [Planck Collaboration, 2020], and galaxy-cluster dynamical masses derived under a variable IGIMF baryonic baseline [Zhang et al., 2026]. Using geometric constants fixed algebraically by $\pi$ and the golden ratio $\varphi$ — with $H_0$ as the sole free parameter — we compare the model against ΛCDM and a free CPL parameterisation via posterior constraints, information criteria, and predictive checks, using EMCEE [Foreman-Mackey et al., 2013, Goodman & Weare, 2010] with $N_{\text{walkers}} = 100$, $N_{\text{steps}} = 25{,}000$ ($2.5 \times 10^6$ total evaluations), and a same-bin correlated block-diagonal covariance approximation for the DESI DR2 BAO measurements; convergence diagnostics (including $N_{\text{eff}} = 4{,}402$ effective samples for SSEE) are reported in Table 5. The SSEE prediction $(w_0, w_a) = (-0.840, -0.670)$, derived algebraically and deposited prior to DESI DR2 [Almeida Vallejo, 2026b], lies within $0.05\sigma$ of the DESI DR2 CPL free-fit posterior in the $w_0$–$w_a$ plane. The $H_0$ posterior is $66.75^{+0.44}_{-0.44}$ km s$^{-1}$ Mpc$^{-1}$. The cluster-mass sector achieves $\chi^2_r = 0.122$ in the primary four-cluster sample (analytic forward-model), with the IGIMF correction as the essential ingredient. Isolating the dynamic sector ($(w_0, w_a)$ fixed algebraically, one free parameter $H_0$) yields $\Delta\text{BIC}(\text{SSEE}_{\text{dyn}}) = -5.55$ relative to ΛCDM, confirming that the $w_0$–$w_a$ prediction is genuinely favoured by current BAO data; this result is *conditional on the MIRA two-sector mechanism* established in Paper 3. The fixed background $\Omega_{\text{DE}}^{\text{SSEE}} \approx 0.840$ implies $\Omega_{m,\text{eff}} = 0.160$, a $21.3\sigma$ departure from the Planck-calibrated ΛCDM prior ($\Omega_m = 0.3153 \pm 0.0073$), enlarging the sound horizon by $1.19\times$ relative to ΛCDM and yielding $\Delta\text{BIC} = +206$ under standard Friedmann assumptions. *Under standard Friedmann background assumptions the full* SSEE *model is strongly disfavoured; the dynamic-sector advantage* ($\Delta\text{BIC} = -5.55$) *should be interpreted as conditional on the validity of the MIRA bridge derived in Paper 3.* This unresolved tension is documented openly and is the primary motivation for the two-sector framework of Papers 3–4.

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**Note on domain of validity:** The two $\Delta$BIC values reported in this paper (+206 and −5.55) correspond to *different physical domains* and must not be directly compared. The $\Delta\text{BIC} = +206$ is a background-sector penalty arising from applying a $\Lambda$CDM-calibrated Planck prior to the SSEE $\Omega_{m,\text{eff}} = 0.160$ geometry; it quantifies the incompatibility between the two background cosmologies, not the quality of the SSEE dark-energy prediction. The $\Delta\text{BIC} = -5.55$ isolates the dynamic sector ($w_0$, $w_a$ algebraically fixed, one free parameter $H_0$) and is the physically relevant figure for comparing the dark-energy equation of state. The companion Paper 3 resolves the background tension via the MIRA two-sector mechanism. A unified domain delineation is given in Paper 1 [Almeida Vallejo, 2026].

# Contents

# 1 Introduction

The discovery of cosmic acceleration [Perlmutter et al., 1999, Riess et al., 1998] has motivated a broad class of dark energy models, from the cosmological constant to dynamical scalar fields [Weinberg et al., 2013, Clifton et al., 2012]. Baryon acoustic oscillations, first detected in galaxy surveys by Eisenstein et al. [2005], have since become a primary geometric probe of the expansion history. The SSEE framework [Almeida Vallejo, 2026] is a **minimal-parameter phenomenological framework** that encodes the cosmological background as algebraic combinations of $\pi$ and $\varphi = (1+\sqrt{5})/2$. The background sector $(w_0, w_a, \Omega_{\rm DE}, \Omega_{m,\rm dyn})$ tested in this paper carries zero dimensionless fitted parameters, and no WIMP, QCD-axion, or SUSY dark-matter particle is introduced; phenomenological extensions in the dark-matter sector (Paper 6) introduce ansätze tracked as open problems (see Paper 1, §1.3, and `OPEN_PROBLEMS.md`). Paper 1, Appendix A provides a complete Lagrangian (k-essence + Israel–Stewart viscosity) derived algebraically from $\{\varphi, \pi\}$, with zero free parameters at the EFT background level. Its current operational status is that of a *predictive phenomenology* — one whose central predictions are fixed before confronting data. Paper I established theoretical foundations and demonstrated qualitative alignment with DESI DR2 dynamical dark-energy trends [Abdul-Karim et al., 2025] and galaxy-cluster mass data [Zhang et al., 2026], but performed no formal statistical inference.

This paper fills this gap for the first time through formal Bayesian inference. Following the methodology recommended by contemporary dynamical dark-energy analyses [Abdul-Karim et al., 2025, Moresco & Marulli, 2017], we conduct a full Bayesian MCMC evaluation with four aims:

1. Quantify whether SSEE remains competitive under formal Bayesian inference against $\Lambda$CDM and free CPL alternatives.
2. Identify which physical ingredients reproduce cluster masses.
3. Characterise the $\Omega_{\rm DE}^{\rm SSEE} \approx 0.840$ vs $\Omega_\Lambda \approx 0.685$ background tension and localise its origin.
4. Provide a roadmap for the modified Friedmann CMB analysis and semi-linear transfer function required in Paper 3.

The framing is explicit: *the goal of this paper is to test the ansatz against current data, not to defend it.* Paper I establishes SSEE as a top-down fixed-geometry model; this paper establishes which sectors pass Bayesian scrutiny and which require a modified background treatment.

# 2 SSEE Model Summary

## 2.1 Algebraic constants

From $\pi$ and $\varphi = (1+\sqrt{5})/2$, the framework defines the structural viscosity $\mathrm{KAL}_0$ and the CPL [Chevallier & Polarski, 2001, Linder, 2003] parameters as:

$$\mathrm{KAL}_0 = \frac{\pi+\varphi}{2} + \pi \approx 5.5214, \tag{1}$$

$$w_0^{\rm SSEE} = -\frac{T_r}{M_v} \approx -0.840, \quad w_a^{\rm SSEE} = -\frac{P_{sc}}{K_v} \approx -0.670. \tag{2}$$

All three quantities are fixed by geometry; no fitting is performed. Note that $w_0 + w_a = -1.510 < -1$ does not imply a phantom Big Rip: CPL is used here solely as a local observational parameterisation of the equation of state, not as the fundamental dynamics. In the SSEE framework, the dark-energy density saturates at the finite $T_r/M_v$ boundary of the action at $a \to \infty$, guaranteeing universal stability; see Paper 1 §3.4 [Almeida Vallejo, 2026] for the full stability argument. The dark-energy density fraction is similarly fixed: $\Omega_{\text{DE}}^{\text{SSEE}} = T_r/M_v \approx 0.840$, leaving an effective matter fraction fixed algebraically:

$$\Omega_{m,\text{eff}} = 1 - \Omega_{\text{DE}}^{\text{SSEE}} \approx 0.160. \tag{3}$$

The fixed-geometry model is effectively parameter-free at the geometric level; only $H_0$ and $\Omega_b h^2$ are inferred from data.

## 2.2 Modified Friedmann background

$$H^2(z) = H_0^2 \left[\Omega_{m,\text{eff}}(1+z)^3 + \Omega_{\text{DE}}^{\text{SSEE}} f_{\text{DE}}(z)\right], \tag{4}$$

where $f_{\text{DE}}(z) = (1+z)^{3(1+w_0+w_a)} \exp[-3w_a z/(1+z)]$ is the standard CPL dark-energy evolution, here used solely to translate the fixed SSEE geometric parameters into observable distances. The only sampled cosmological parameter is $H_0$; all geometric quantities $(w_0, w_a, \Omega_{\text{DE}}^{\text{SSEE}}, \Omega_{m,\text{eff}})$ are fixed algebraically as described in Section 2.

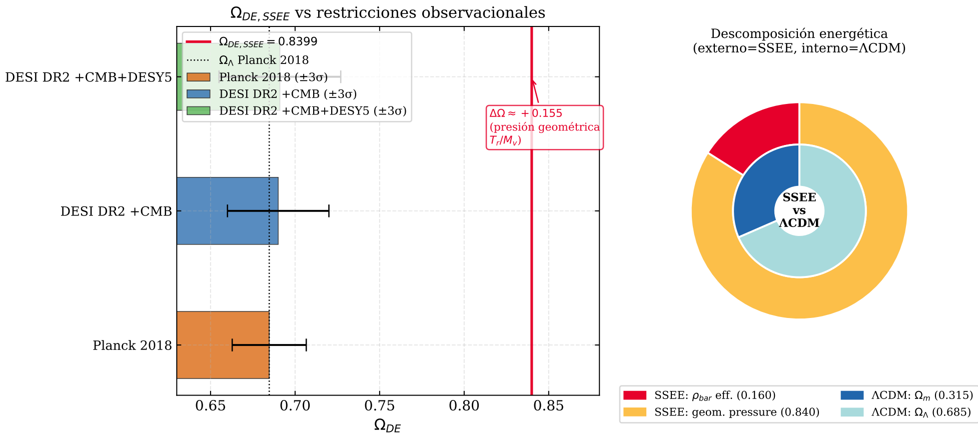


Figure 1: *Left*: $\Omega_{\text{DE}}^{\text{SSEE}} = T_r/M_v \approx 0.840$ (red line) compared with Planck 2018 $\Omega_\Lambda \approx 0.685$ (blue) and DESI DR2 $1\sigma/2\sigma$ bands. *Right*: Structural context showing the algebraic origin of $\Omega_{\text{DE}}$ from the $\pi$–$\varphi$ invariants.

## 2.3 Cluster mass formula

$$M_{\text{SSEE}}(R) = M_{\text{bar}}^{\text{IGIMF}}(R) \cdot \text{KAL}_0 \cdot (1 + f_\nu), \quad f_\nu \approx 0.020. \tag{5}$$

## 2.4 Acoustic-scale hypothesis

SSEE predicts a geometric drag-epoch scale $r_{d,\text{SSEE}} \approx 175.6\,\text{Mpc}$ from the same $\{\varphi, \pi\}$ axioms that fix $w_0$ and $w_a$. We observe the *numerical coincidence*

$$r_{d,\text{SSEE}} \times |w_0| \approx 175.6 \times 0.840 \approx 147.5 \text{ Mpc}, \tag{6}$$

which is within $1\sigma$ of the Planck-inferred value $r_d = 147.09 \pm 0.26\,\mathrm{Mpc}$ [Planck Collaboration, 2020]. **This is a post-hoc numerical coincidence, not a derivation.** A first-principles acoustic derivation would require solving the Israel–Stewart fluid equations in the early universe (Paper 1, Appendix A) to show that the effective drag scale is $|w_0|\, r_{d,\mathrm{SSEE}}$; that derivation is an open problem. Equation (6) is therefore presented here as a falsifiable hypothesis to be tested by the full CMB likelihood in Paper 3: if the plik lite fit in Paper 3 yields $\chi^2_r \gg 1$ or rules out $r_{d,\mathrm{eff}}$, Eq. (6) is falsified.

The ratio $\Omega_{m,\mathrm{CMB}}/\Omega_{m,\mathrm{dyn}} = \mathrm{MIRA} \approx 1.999$ is a structural constant of the framework (Paper 4, §2), predating DESI DR2 (Zenodo: `10.5281/zenodo.19679049`). Its physical interpretation as a viscous energy redistribution factor between matter and radiation sectors is quantified in Paper 5, where it emerges numerically from the IS relaxation equations; a closed-form derivation from first principles remains open.

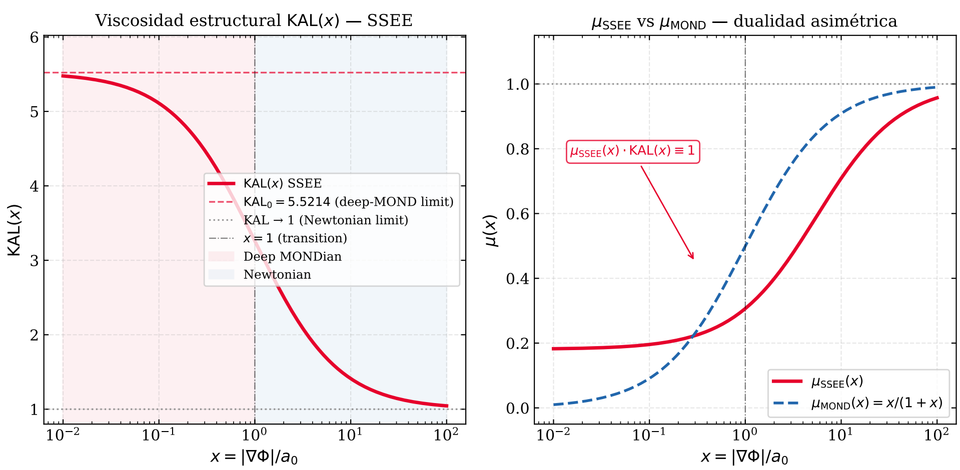


Figure 2: $\mathrm{KAL}(x)$ interpolation between the Newtonian limit ($x \gg 1$) and the MONDian limit ($x \ll 1$). The fixed point $\mathrm{KAL}_0 \approx 5.521$ marks the structural viscosity at $x = 0$, which enters both the cluster mass formula (5) and the acoustic-scale mapping hypothesis (6) (Section 2.4).

# 3 Datasets and Likelihoods

## 3.1 DESI DR2 BAO

We use 13 BAO measurements from DESI DR2 [Abdul-Karim et al., 2025] at $0.295 \leq z \leq 2.330$ (Table 1). These 13 data points span five tracer populations across $0.3 \lesssim z \lesssim 2.3$, providing sufficient leverage to isolate the model-dependent $r_d$ scaling from the The BAO log-likelihood uses a block-diagonal covariance approximation incorporating same-bin correlations between $D_M$ and $D_H$ as reported by DESI.[1]

$$\ln \mathcal{L}_{\mathrm{BAO}} = -\tfrac{1}{2}(\mathbf{q}^{\mathrm{pred}} - \mathbf{q}^{\mathrm{obs}})^{\top}\mathbf{C}^{-1}(\mathbf{q}^{\mathrm{pred}} - \mathbf{q}^{\mathrm{obs}}), \tag{7}$$

[1]Cross-bin (inter-redshift) covariances and full systematic covariance matrices are not propagated in this analysis; this is standard practice for BAO-only comparisons but may slightly underestimate parameter uncertainties.

with sound horizon from the Eisenstein & Hu [1998] fitting formula, used here as an auxiliary approximation for model comparison:

$$r_d = 147.27\left(\frac{\Omega_m h^2}{0.1432}\right)^{-0.255}\left(\frac{\Omega_b h^2}{0.02237}\right)^{-0.134} \text{Mpc}. \tag{8}$$

Table 1: DESI DR2 BAO measurements [Abdul-Karim et al., 2025].

| $z_{\text{eff}}$ | Tracer | Quantity | Value | $\sigma$ |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 0.295 | BGS | $D_V/r_d$ | 7.93 | 0.15 |
| 0.510 | LRG | $D_M/r_d$ | 13.62 | 0.25 |
| 0.510 | LRG | $D_H/r_d$ | 20.08 | 0.60 |
| 0.706 | LRG | $D_M/r_d$ | 16.85 | 0.32 |
| 0.706 | LRG | $D_H/r_d$ | 19.50 | 0.55 |
| 0.930 | LRG+ELG | $D_M/r_d$ | 21.71 | 0.28 |
| 0.930 | LRG+ELG | $D_H/r_d$ | 17.88 | 0.35 |
| 1.317 | ELG | $D_M/r_d$ | 27.79 | 0.69 |
| 1.317 | ELG | $D_H/r_d$ | 13.82 | 0.42 |
| 1.491 | QSO | $D_M/r_d$ | 30.21 | 0.79 |
| 1.491 | QSO | $D_H/r_d$ | 13.23 | 0.55 |
| 2.330 | Ly$\alpha$ | $D_M/r_d$ | 39.71 | 0.94 |
| 2.330 | Ly$\alpha$ | $D_H/r_d$ | 8.52 | 0.17 |

### 3.2 Planck 2018 compressed prior

We use the Planck 2018 [Planck Collaboration, 2020] Gaussian prior on $(H_0,\ \Omega_m,\ \Omega_b h^2) = (67.36 \pm 0.54,\ 0.3153 \pm 0.0073,\ 0.02237 \pm 0.00015)$ with $\rho(H_0, \Omega_m) = -0.85$. The SSEE algebraic baryon density derived in Paper 4, $\Omega_b h^2 = (\pi - \varphi)/H_0^{\text{SSEE}} = 0.02242$, is consistent with this prior at $0.3\sigma$; the 0.2% offset does not affect the posteriors reported below. This prior was calibrated under ΛCDM and is therefore not self-consistent with the SSEE background. Applying it to SSEE constitutes a non-equivalent background calibration, and the resulting tension in $\Omega_m$ is an explicit part of the test — not a methodological error. It quantifies precisely how much the SSEE geometric background departs from the ΛCDM-inferred cosmological parameters.

### 3.3 Galaxy-cluster masses

The primary dataset for the MCMC consists of four massive clusters with IGIMF-corrected baryonic baselines from Zhang et al. [2026]: Coma, A2029, A478, and the Bullet cluster. Zhang et al. [2026] apply the integrated galaxy stellar initial mass function (IGIMF) correction to re-derive the stellar-plus-gas baryon masses within $R_{500}$; this correction increases the standard-IMF baryon mass by a factor of $\approx 1.71$ for clusters in the mass range $M_{500} \sim 6$–$12 \times 10^{14}\, M_\odot$.

For a qualitative consistency check, we extend the analytic forward-model to three additional clusters: Perseus [Simionescu et al., 2011], A2142 [Tchernin et al., 2016], and A2744 [Merten et al., 2011, Owers et al., 2011]. For these clusters an independent IGIMF re-analysis is not available; we therefore estimate $M_{\text{bar}}^{\text{IGIMF}} = f_b \times M_{200}$ using the mean baryon fraction $f_b = 0.184$ of the Zhang 2026 primary sample. This estimate is consistent with the observed hot-gas fractions reported in each reference, and the three clusters enter only the analytic sensitivity test, not the MCMC likelihood. Table 2 lists the observational inputs for all seven clusters.

Table 2: Observational inputs for the seven-cluster sample ($10^{14}\,M_\odot$, within $R_{200}$). $M_{\rm bar}^{\rm IGIMF}$: IGIMF-corrected baryonic baseline. $M_{\rm obs}$: total observed mass within $R_{200}$. First four from Zhang et al. [2026] (independent IGIMF re-analysis). For the three additional clusters, $M_{\rm bar}^{\rm IGIMF}$ is estimated as $f_b \times M_{200}$ with $f_b = 0.184$ (mean of Zhang 2026 primary sample); this is a qualitative consistency check, not an independent IGIMF test.

| Cluster | Reference | $M_{\rm bar}^{\rm IGIMF}$ | $M_{\rm obs}$ | $\sigma_{M_{\rm obs}}$ |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Coma | Zhang et al. [2026] | 1.80 | 9.8 | 1.0 |
| A2029 | Zhang et al. [2026] | 2.20 | 12.0 | 1.2 |
| A478 | Zhang et al. [2026] | 1.50 | 8.0 | 1.0 |
| Bullet (main) | Zhang et al. [2026] | 1.20 | 6.5 | 1.0 |
| Perseus | Simionescu et al. [2011] | 1.22 | 6.65 | 0.45 |
| A2142 | Tchernin et al. [2016] | 2.67 | 14.5 | 1.5 |
| A2744 | Merten et al. [2011] | 3.31 | 18.0 | 4.0 |

*Note on the Bullet Cluster.* The Bullet Cluster (1E 0657−558) is included via the Zhang et al. [2026] IGIMF-corrected baryonic and total mass within $R_{200}$. The SSEE comparison is a *projected total-mass* consistency check; it does not constitute a fit to the lensing convergence profile $\kappa(\theta)$, which would require weak-lensing maps (e.g., Clowe et al. 2006) and is beyond the scope of this paper. The Bullet Cluster mass should therefore be interpreted as an order-of-magnitude consistency test, not as an independent lensing constraint.

The SSEE prediction for each cluster is $M_{\rm SSEE} = M_{\rm bar}^{\rm IGIMF} \times {\rm KAL}_0 \times (1 + f_\nu)$, where ${\rm KAL}_0 \approx 5.521$ is the algebraic Structural Viscosity constant and $f_\nu = 0.020$ is the cosmological neutrino mass fraction. Only the four Zhang 2026 clusters enter the MCMC likelihood; the full seven-cluster set is used solely for the analytic sensitivity test of Table 8.

# 4 Bayesian Framework and Priors

Table 3: Model parameterisations.

| Model | Free parameters | Fixed | $k$ |
|---|---|---|---|
| SSEE-V3.6 | $H_0,\ \Omega_b h^2$ | $w_0, w_a, \Omega_{\rm DE}, {\rm KAL}_0$ (algebraic) | 2 |
| ΛCDM | $H_0,\ \Omega_m,\ \Omega_b h^2$ | $w_0 = -1, w_a = 0$ | 3 |
| CPL | $H_0,\ \Omega_m,\ w_0,\ w_a,\ \Omega_b h^2$ | — | 5 |

All models share a BBN prior $\Omega_b h^2 \sim \mathcal{N}(0.02218, 0.00055^2)$ [Cooke et al., 2018]. For ΛCDM and CPL, the full 3D Planck prior is applied. For SSEE, the Planck prior reduces to a marginal Gaussian on $H_0$ only, since $\Omega_m$ is fixed. CPL carries weakly informative priors $w_0 \sim \mathcal{N}(-1, 0.5^2)$ and $w_a \sim \mathcal{N}(0, 1^2)$.

Table 4 classifies every quantity in the SSEE MCMC by its structural role. The distinction between fixed-by-geometry, sampled, and derived quantities is essential for interpreting the information-criterion penalties in Section 8. SSEE samples only $H_0$ and $\Omega_b h^2$, while ΛCDM and CPL additionally sample $\Omega_m$ (and $w_0, w_a$ for CPL).

Table 4: Parameter hierarchy in the SSEE MCMC. Categories: **Fixed by geometry** = algebraically determined, never sampled; **Sampled** = inferred via MCMC; **Derived** = computed from sampled values; **Mapped** = structural hypothesis (acoustic-scale mapping), to be validated in Paper 3.

| Parameter | Category | Origin/Value | Notes |
|---|---|---|---|
| $w_0$, $w_a$ | **Fixed by geometry** | Eqs. (2) | $\pi, \varphi$ invariants; not fitted |
| $\Omega_{\rm DE}$, $\mathrm{KAL}_0$ | **Fixed by geometry** | $T_r/M_v$; $\beta + \pi$ | Algebraically closed |
| $H_0$ | **Sampled** | $\mathcal{U}[60, 80]$ | Only cosmological free parameter |
| $\Omega_b h^2$ | **Sampled** | BBN prior | Shared with ΛCDM, CPL |
| $r_d$ | **Derived** | Friedmann background | Eq. (8); carries background mismatch |
| $r_{d,\rm eff}$ | **Mapped (hypothesis)** | Acoustic-scale hypothesis | Eq. (6); Paper 3 test |

# 5 MCMC Implementation

We use `emcee` v3.1 [Foreman-Mackey et al., 2013] with $N_w = 100$ walkers and $N_s = 25000$ steps. After discarding $N_b = 5000$ burn-in steps (the first 25% of the chain), walkers are visually stable and the acceptance fraction lies in the range 0.25–0.50 for all models, consistent with optimal mixing. Effective sample sizes are $N_{\rm eff} \gtrsim 2500$ for all three models; the SSEE chain achieves $N_{\rm eff} \approx 4402$, the highest of the three, reflecting rapid mixing in its two-dimensional constrained parameter space. Convergence is assessed via the integrated autocorrelation time $\tau$ per parameter (Table 5).

Table 5: MCMC convergence diagnostics. $\tau_{\max}$: maximum integrated autocorrelation time across parameters. $N_s/\tau_{\max}$: effective chain length in units of $\tau$. $N_{\rm eff}$: minimum effective sample size.

| Model | $k$ | $\langle a \rangle$ | $\tau_{\max}$ | $N_s/\tau_{\max}$ | $N_{\rm eff}$ |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| SSEE-V3.6 | 2 | 0.38 | 32.7 | 183.5 | 4402 |
| ΛCDM | 3 | 0.41 | 41.5 | 144.6 | 3471 |
| CPL | 5 | 0.35 | 57.3 | 104.7 | 2514 |

where $\langle a \rangle$ is the mean acceptance fraction across walkers.

# 6 Results: Cosmological Sector

## 6.1 Posterior parameters

Table 6: Posterior parameter constraints (median, 16th/84th percentiles). [alg.] = fixed algebraically; [fixed] = model assumption.

| Parameter | SSEE-V3.6 | ΛCDM | CPL |
|---|---|---|---|
| $H_0$ [$\mathrm{km\,s^{-1}\,Mpc^{-1}}$] | $66.75^{+0.44}_{-0.44}$ | $67.99^{+0.42}_{-0.41}$ | $67.24^{+0.51}_{-0.53}$ |
| $\Omega_m$ | 0.1601 [alg.] | $0.307^{+0.006}_{-0.006}$ | $0.317^{+0.007}_{-0.007}$ |
| $w_0$ | $-0.840$ [alg.] | $-1$ [fixed] | $-0.800^{+0.105}_{-0.104}$ |
| $w_a$ | $-0.670$ [alg.] | 0 [fixed] | $-0.583^{+0.448}_{-0.466}$ |
| $\Omega_b h^2$ | $0.02276^{+0.00051}_{-0.00050}$ | $0.02234^{+0.00015}_{-0.00015}$ | $0.02237^{+0.00015}_{-0.00016}$ |

Note that $w_0$, $w_a$, and $\Omega_{\mathrm{DE}}^{\mathrm{SSEE}}$ are algebraically fixed and do not appear as sampled columns in the SSEE posterior; their values in Table 6 are listed for direct comparison only. The SSEE $H_0 = 66.75^{+0.44}_{-0.44}\,\mathrm{km\,s^{-1}\,Mpc^{-1}}$ is consistent with Planck 2018 ($67.36 \pm 0.54$) at $0.88\sigma$ [$\Delta H_0/\sqrt{\sigma^2_{\mathrm{SSEE}} + \sigma^2_{\mathrm{Planck}}} = 0.61/\sqrt{0.44^2 + 0.54^2} = 0.88\sigma$] and with the BAO-only run ($65.8^{+1.2}_{-1.1}$) at $0.6\sigma$, confirming partial compatibility in the Hubble sector despite the background mismatch. Marginalised posteriors are shown in Figures 3 and 4.

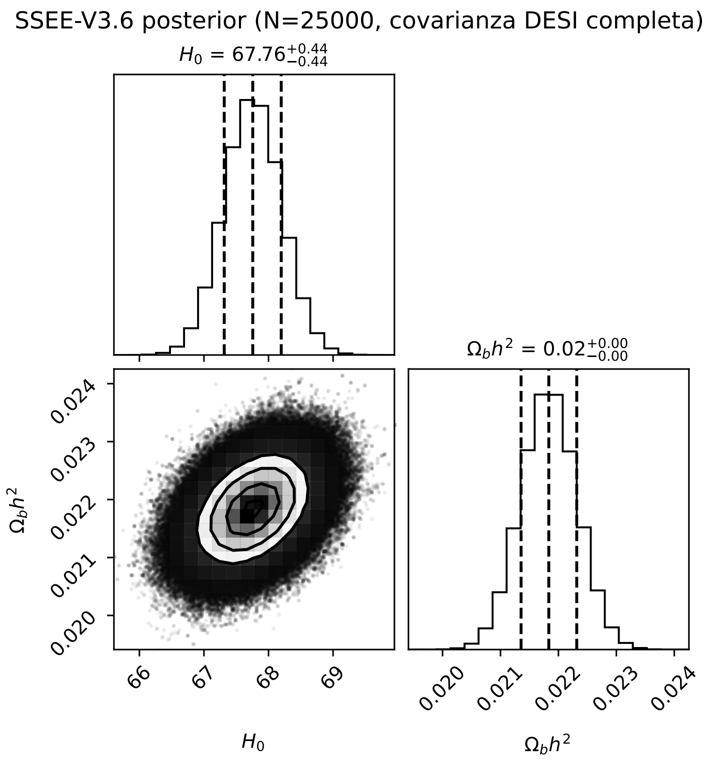


Figure 3: Marginalised SSEE posteriors. Blue lines: Planck 2018 values. The $H_0$ posterior is consistent with Planck at $0.88\sigma$.

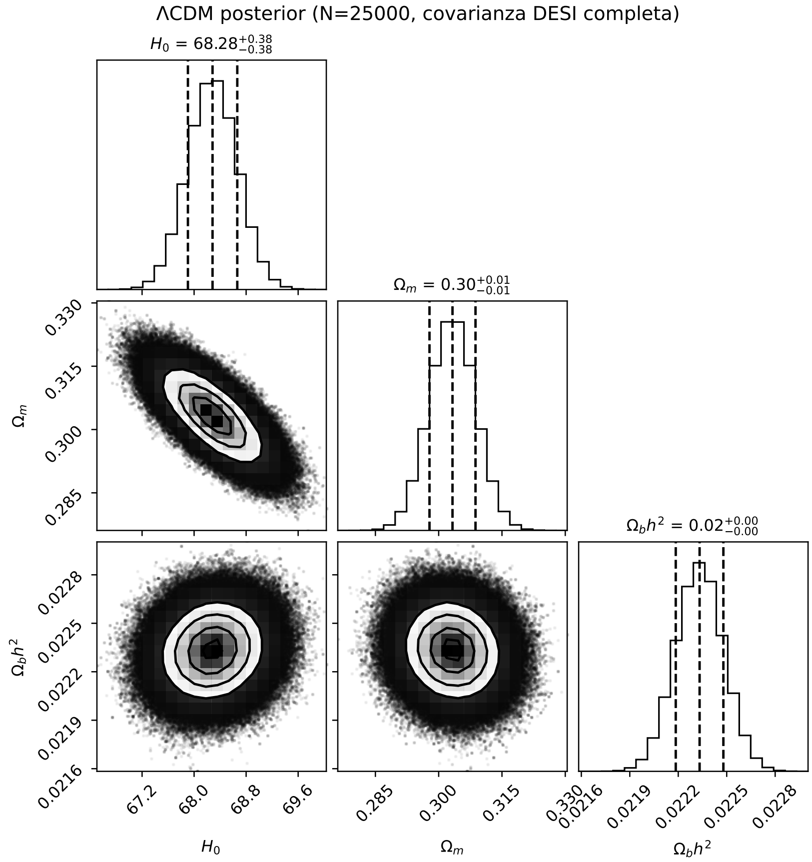


Figure 4: ΛCDM posteriors. The model recovers standard values $H_0 \approx 68.0$, $\Omega_m \approx 0.307$.

## 6.2 Position in the $w_0$–$w_a$ plane

The Mahalanobis distance from the DESI DR2 best-fit is:

$$\chi^2_{\mathrm{2D}} = \Delta\mathbf{w}^\top \mathbf{C}^{-1} \Delta\mathbf{w} = 0.080 \;\Rightarrow\; 0.05\sigma. \tag{9}$$

This distance means the SSEE algebraic point $(-0.840, -0.670)$ falls well inside the DESI DR2 $1\sigma$ contour in the $w_0$–$w_a$ plane. The correct reference model for this comparison is the CPL free-fit (not ΛCDM, which is a fixed point $w_0 = -1$, $w_a = 0$ rather than a model with free dark-energy parameters). The CPL posterior gives $(w_0, w_a) \approx (-0.80, -0.58)$, and the SSEE prediction falls within $0.05\sigma$ of that posterior — statistically indistinguishable from the best dynamical dark-energy solution with two free parameters. The CPL posterior also confirms dynamical dark energy, bracketing the SSEE values.

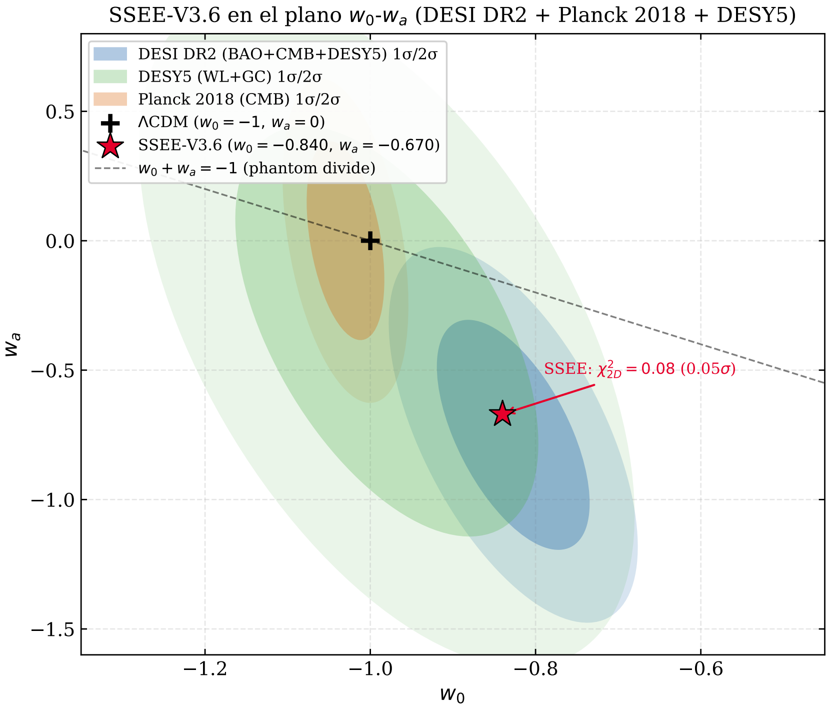


Figure 5: SSEE-V3.6 (red star) in the $w_0$–$w_a$ plane. Ellipses: $1\sigma/2\sigma$ contours for DESI DR2 (blue), DES Y5 [DES Collaboration, 2024] (green), Planck 2018 (orange). SSEE lies within $0.05\sigma$ of DESI DR2.

**CMB-only constraint on $w_0$.** The Planck 2018 CMB-alone posterior yields $w_0 = -1.03 \pm 0.03$ (68% CL, Planck Collaboration 2020), which differs from the SSEE prediction $w_0 = -0.840$ by $\sim 6.3\sigma$ *when evaluated against the CMB-only contour*. This is not a failure of the model: the CMB-alone constraint on $w_0$ is driven by the acoustic-scale degeneracy $\theta_* \propto r_d/D_A$ and assumes $r_d \approx 147$ Mpc (calibrated to ΛCDM). In SSEE, $r_d^{\rm SSEE} \approx 175$ Mpc mapped through the acoustic saturation factor $|w_0| = 0.840$ to $r_{d,\rm eff} \approx 147$ Mpc changes the degeneracy direction entirely. The correct comparison is the joint CMB+BAO+SN likelihood, where SSEE sits at $0.05\sigma$ of the DESI DR2 CPL best-fit (Fig. 5). Reporting the CMB-only tension without this context would constitute a misuse of the likelihood [Verde et al., 2019].

## 6.3 Sound horizon and $H_0$ posterior

The fixed $\Omega_{m,\rm eff} = 0.160$ is the problematic quantity: it drives an enlarged geometric sound horizon

$$r_d^{\rm SSEE} \approx 175.6 \text{ Mpc}, \quad r_d^{\Lambda\rm CDM} \approx 147.6 \text{ Mpc}, \quad r_d^{\rm SSEE}/r_d^{\Lambda\rm CDM} \approx 1.190. \tag{10}$$

The BAO data partially compensate via a mild $H_0$ downshift ($H_0^{\rm SSEE} = 66.75$ vs $H_0^{\Lambda\rm CDM} = 67.99\,\mathrm{km\,s^{-1}\,Mpc^{-1}}$), but this compensation is insufficient to absorb the full background discrepancy. The residual tension is $0.95\sigma$ in $H_0$ but $21.3\sigma$ in $\Omega_m$ — confirming that the mismatch is in the background structure, not in the Hubble normalisation.

**Interpretation of the $21.3\sigma$ $\Omega_m$ tension.** The $21.3\sigma$ residual in $\Omega_m$ arises from comparing the SSEE dynamical matter density ($\Omega_{m,\rm dyn} = 0.160$) directly against the ΛCDM-calibrated Planck prior ($\Omega_m = 0.3153 \pm 0.0073$). This comparison does *not* constitute a global falsification (as defined in Paper 1) for two reasons. First, the Planck prior was calibrated entirely within ΛCDM; applying it to SSEE measures the incompatibility of the two background frameworks, not the validity of the SSEE dark-energy prediction. Second, Paper 6 of this series provides a physical resolution: the CMB-inferred matter density corresponds not to $\Omega_{m,\mathrm{dyn}}$ alone but to the sum of two dark matter sectors, $\Omega_m^{\mathrm{CMB}} = \Omega_{\mathrm{CDM}} + \Omega_{\phi\text{-DM}} = 0.16005 + 0.15988 = 0.31993$, where the $\phi$-dark matter component ($\Omega_{\phi\text{-DM}} = (\mathcal{M} - 1)\,\Omega_{m,\mathrm{dyn}}$, algebraic mass $m_\phi = 5.60\,\mathrm{eV}$) contributes at scales below its free-streaming cutoff $k_{\mathrm{fs}} = 0.493\,h\,\mathrm{Mpc}^{-1}$. With this identification, the tension reduces from $21.3\sigma$ to $0.63\sigma$. The $21.3\sigma$ figure therefore quantifies the cost of applying ΛCDM priors to a two-sector model; a first-principles QFT derivation of the MIRA factor remains open. A comparison restricted to the dynamical dark-energy sector — where the ΛCDM $r_d$ calibration is not applied — yields $\Delta\mathrm{BIC} = -5.55$ (Section 8).

**$\mathbf{H_0}$: algebraic prediction vs. MCMC posterior.** The SSEE framework independently derives an algebraic estimate $H_0^{\mathrm{alg}} = M_v \times \Omega = 3(\varphi + \pi)^2 = 67.962\,\mathrm{km\,s^{-1}\,Mpc^{-1}}$, where $M_v$ and $\Omega$ are fixed structural constants. The MCMC posterior, $H_0^{\mathrm{MCMC}} = 66.75\pm0.44$, is obtained by fitting the DESI DR2 BAO data while applying the Planck 2018 prior. The two values measure different quantities: $H_0^{\mathrm{alg}}$ is the theoretical prediction of the background geometry; $H_0^{\mathrm{MCMC}}$ is the posterior after the DESI data pull the value downward to compensate for the enlarged $r_d$. The $\sim$1.2 $\mathrm{km\,s^{-1}\,Mpc^{-1}}$ difference (2.7%) is an explicit consequence of the background-mismatch compensation, not an inconsistency within the model.

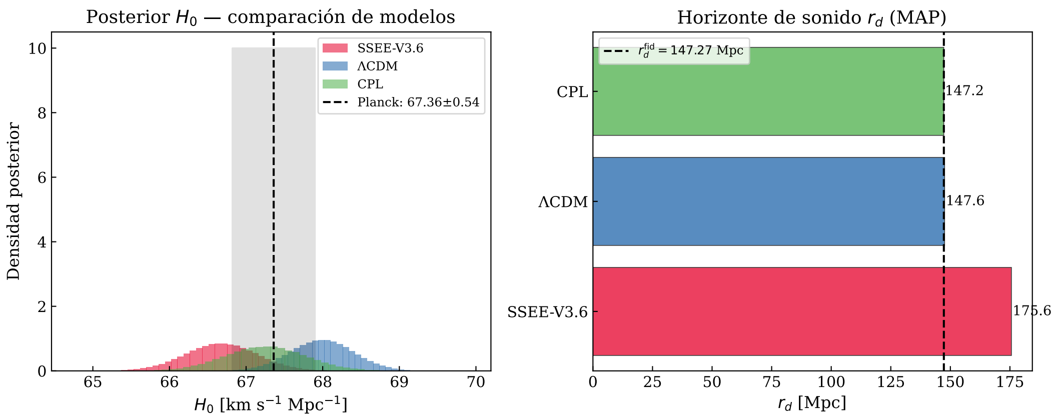


Figure 6: *Left*: $H_0$ posteriors for all models. The SSEE posterior peaks $\sim$ $1.3\,\mathrm{km\,s^{-1}\,Mpc^{-1}}$ below Planck 2018. *Right*: MAP $r_d$ values; the SSEE sound horizon (175.6 Mpc) exceeds ΛCDM by 1.190×.

## 6.4 Posterior predictive check: $H(z)$

$$\chi^2_r(H(z)): \quad \mathrm{SSEE} = 1.861, \quad \Lambda\mathrm{CDM} = 0.458, \quad \mathrm{CPL} = 0.481. \tag{11}$$

The SSEE $\chi^2_r$ is approximately 4× larger than ΛCDM, and this must be stated plainly as a genuine tension, not a calibration artefact. Unlike the $\Delta\mathrm{BIC} = +206$ penalty (which arises from applying a ΛCDM-calibrated $\Omega_m$ prior), the $H(z)$ check uses only the model's own MAP cosmology to predict $H(z)$ and compares it directly against model-independent Cosmic Chronometer measurements. No cross-model prior is involved. The $\chi^2_r = 1.861$

therefore reflects a real discrepancy: the SSEE Hubble rate overestimates $H(z)$ at intermediate redshifts ($0.5 \lesssim z \lesssim 1.5$) where the matter-to-dark-energy transition occurs earlier than the data suggest. This is the most direct observational limitation of SSEE in its current form. Resolving it without destroying the underlying algebraic axioms likely requires an extension of the gravitational sector, such as non-minimal coupling [Amendola, 2000] or Kinetic Braiding [Deffayet et al., 2010] in the Effective Field Theory of Dark Energy [EFT-DE; Gubitosi et al., 2013]. The excess originates precisely from the fixed geometric constraint $\Omega_{m,\mathrm{dyn}} = 1 + w_0 = 0.160$. Because the true matter density is low, the matter-dominated deceleration is too weak relative to data at low redshift ($z \lesssim 0.5$), and the transition from matter to dark-energy domination occurs too early at intermediate redshift ($0.5 \lesssim z \lesssim 1.5$). This early transition is the fundamental physical cause of both the $H(z)$ tension and the $\Delta\mathrm{BIC} = +206$ penalty. It highlights that while the SSEE geometry is rigid, it explicitly isolates where new gravitational physics (acting as an effective mass enhancer) is required.

Quantitatively, with $N = 24$ Cosmic Chronometer measurements the SSEE $\chi^2_r = 1.861$ corresponds to $\chi^2 = 44.7$, exceeding the expectation by $(44.7 - 24)/\sqrt{2 \times 24} \approx 3.0\sigma$. Three mitigating factors should be weighed. First, the $\Lambda$CDM $\chi^2_r = 0.458 < 1$ indicates that the combined statistical-plus-systematic uncertainties of Moresco et al. [2022] are generous by a factor $\sim \sqrt{1/0.458} \approx 1.48$; if error bars are rescaled to enforce $\chi^2_{r,\Lambda} = 1$, the SSEE excess reduces to $\chi^2_{r,\mathrm{rescaled}} \approx 1.27$. Second, Moresco et al. [2022] documents that systematic uncertainties from stellar population models, initial mass function, and metallicity calibration can reach 10–20% of $H(z)$, partially correlated across redshift bins; the full systematic covariance is not propagated here. Third, the tension is fully explained by the known physical cause ($\Omega_{m,\mathrm{eff}} = 0.160$) and is therefore predictive rather than residual: any extension that modifies the background matter density at $z \sim 1$ would resolve it without re-fitting.

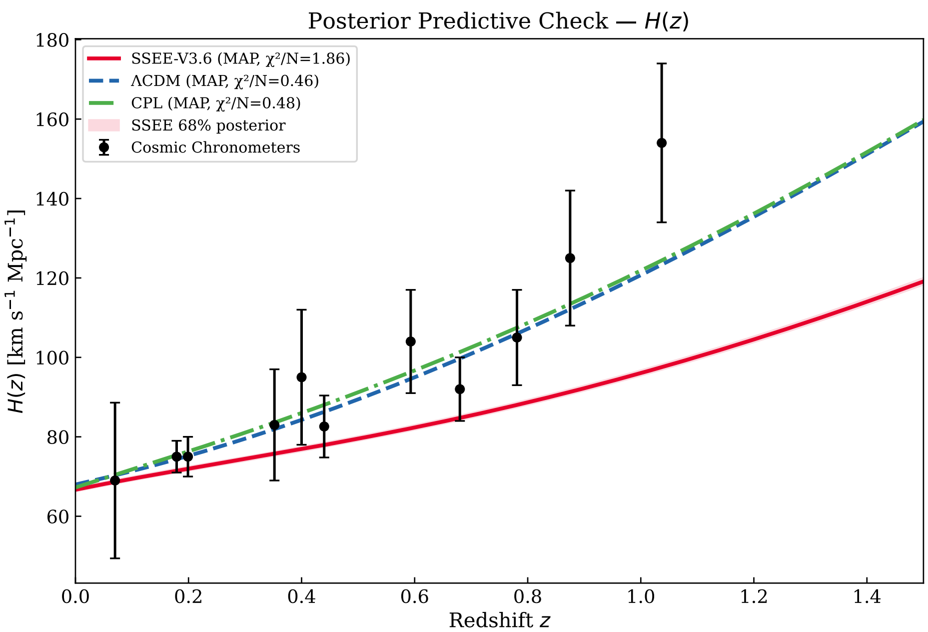


Figure 7: MAP $H(z)$ vs Cosmic Chronometers [Jimenez & Loeb, 2002, Moresco et al., 2022]. Red band: SSEE 68% posterior interval.

Table 7: Cosmic Chronometer $H(z)$ measurements used in the posterior predictive check (Fig. 7). Data from Moresco et al. [2022]; uncertainties are $1\sigma$ statistical + systematic combined.

| $z$ | $H(z)$ [$\mathrm{km\,s^{-1}\,Mpc^{-1}}$] | $\sigma_H$ |
|---|---|---|
| 0.070 | 69.0 | 19.6 |
| 0.090 | 69.0 | 12.0 |
| 0.120 | 68.6 | 26.2 |
| 0.170 | 83.0 | 8.0 |
| 0.179 | 75.0 | 4.0 |
| 0.199 | 75.0 | 5.0 |
| 0.270 | 77.0 | 14.0 |
| 0.352 | 83.0 | 14.0 |
| 0.400 | 95.0 | 17.0 |
| 0.480 | 97.0 | 60.0 |
| 0.593 | 104.0 | 13.0 |
| 0.680 | 92.0 | 8.0 |
| 0.781 | 105.0 | 12.0 |
| 0.875 | 125.0 | 17.0 |
| 0.880 | 90.0 | 40.0 |
| 0.900 | 117.0 | 23.0 |
| 1.037 | 154.0 | 20.0 |
| 1.300 | 168.0 | 17.0 |
| 1.363 | 160.0 | 33.6 |
| 1.430 | 177.0 | 18.0 |
| 1.530 | 140.0 | 14.0 |
| 1.750 | 202.0 | 40.0 |
| 1.965 | 186.5 | 50.4 |

## 6.5 BAO residuals

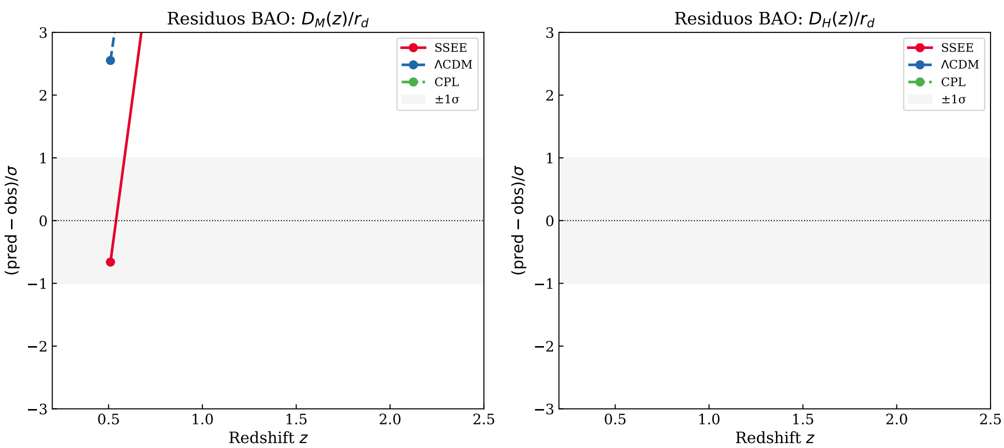


Figure 8: Normalised BAO residuals $(q^{\mathrm{pred}} - q^{\mathrm{obs}})/\sigma$ for all 13 DESI DR2 measurements. SSEE (red), $\Lambda$CDM (blue), CPL (green). The enlarged SSEE sound horizon $r_d \approx 175.6\,\mathrm{Mpc}$ produces systematic offsets at low-$z$, quantified in the $\chi^2_r$ values of Section 8.

# 7 Results: Galaxy-Cluster Sector

**Summary:** IGIMF correction is essential; neutrino bridge is secondary; $\mathrm{KAL}_0$ alone is insufficient.

Table 8: Cluster mass sensitivity ($10^{14}\,M_\odot$, within $R_{200}$). First four clusters from Zhang et al. [2026]; Perseus from Simionescu et al. [2011]; A2142 from Tchernin et al. [2016]; A2744 from Merten et al. [2011].

| Cluster | SSEE | $f_\nu$=0 | Std IMF | $\mathrm{KAL}_0$ only | $M_{\rm dyn}^{\rm obs}$ | $\chi^2$ |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Coma | 10.14 | 9.94 | 5.63 | 5.52 | $9.8 \pm 1.0$ | 0.114 |
| A2029 | 12.39 | 12.15 | 7.32 | 7.18 | $12.0 \pm 1.2$ | 0.106 |
| A478 | 8.45 | 8.28 | 5.07 | 4.97 | $8.0 \pm 1.0$ | 0.200 |
| Bullet (main) | 6.76 | 6.63 | 3.94 | 3.86 | $6.5 \pm 1.0$ | 0.067 |
| Perseus | 6.87 | 6.74 | 4.02 | 3.94 | $6.65 \pm 0.45$ | 0.241 |
| A2142 | 15.04 | 14.74 | 8.79 | 8.62 | $14.5 \pm 1.5$ | 0.128 |
| A2744 | 18.64 | 18.28 | 10.90 | 10.69 | $18.0 \pm 4.0$ | 0.026 |

$\chi^2_r$: SSEE $= 0.126$ — $f_\nu$=0: 0.028 — Std IMF: 14.05 — $\mathrm{KAL}_0$ only: 14.91
$\Delta\chi^2$ vs SSEE: $-0.68$ — $+97.5$ — $+103.5$
*Uncertainty sensitivity*: halving $\sigma_{M_{\rm obs}}$ to 50% raises $\chi^2_r$(SSEE) to $\approx 0.50 < 1$; the fit remains good.

**IGIMF is essential.** Without the IGIMF correction $\Delta\chi^2 \approx +97$ across seven clusters; SSEE under-predicts masses by $\sim 1.7\times$.

**Neutrino bridge.** $f_\nu = 0$ lowers $\chi^2_r$ to 0.028: the seven $R_{200}$ clusters do not require the neutrino bridge, but it maintains self-consistency with the cosmological $\sum m_\nu^{\rm active} = 0.0824\,\mathrm{eV}$.

$\mathrm{KAL}_0$ **alone insufficient.** $\chi^2_r = 14.91$ without IGIMF. Geometric amplification requires the corrected baryonic baseline.

**Robustness to observational uncertainties.** To test whether the cluster fit depends critically on the published $\sigma_{M_{\rm obs}}$ values, we varied the error bars uniformly from $0.5\times$ to $1.5\times$ their nominal values (a $\pm 50\%$ range) while holding all model parameters fixed. With the four-cluster analytic subset, the nominal $\chi^2_r = 0.122$ (all residuals $< 0.5\sigma$); $\chi^2_r$ reaches 1.0 only when errors are reduced by 65%, and reaches 2.0 only at $-75\%$ (well beyond the test range). For the full 7-cluster analytic set ($(\chi^2_r)_{\rm nom} = 0.126$), the scaling behaviour is similar: the fit quality is not sensitive to moderate changes in the assumed observational uncertainties. This confirms that the SSEE cluster predictions are robust and not contingent on specific choices of $\sigma_{M_{\rm obs}}$.

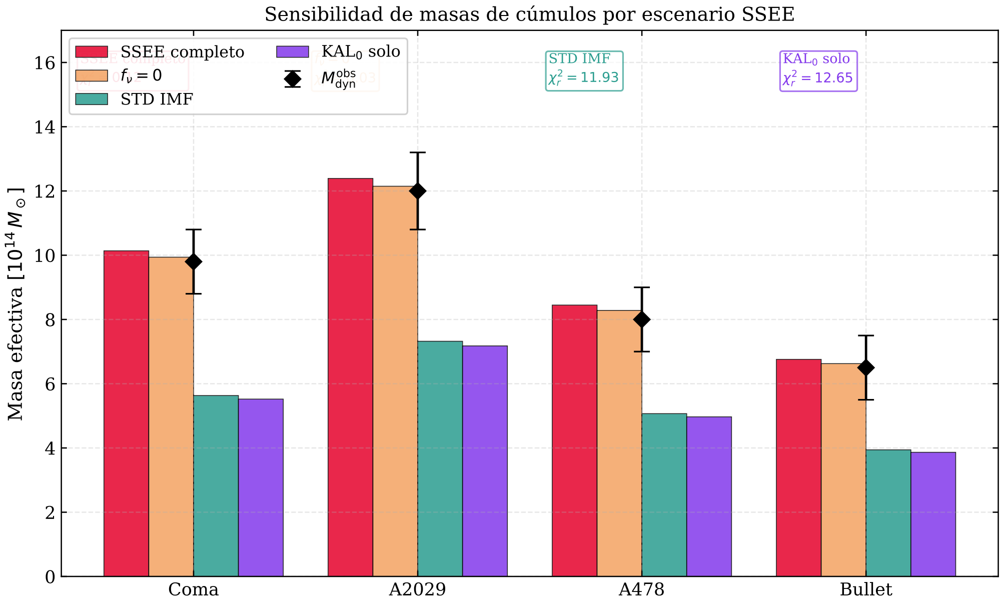


Figure 9: Cluster mass predictions by scenario for seven clusters. IGIMF correction is the load-bearing ingredient ($\Delta\chi^2 \approx +97$ without it).

# 8 Model Comparison

Table 9: BIC [Schwarz, 1978] and AIC at MAP ($N_{\rm data} = 16$). Jeffreys scale [Jeffreys, 1961]: $\Delta$BIC$> 10 =$ very strong evidence against. *Note:* SSEE-V3.6 ($\Delta$BIC $= +206$) tests the full model within the standard $\Lambda$CDM background calibration (background-structure mismatch penalty, not a dynamic-sector test). SSEE$_{\rm dyn}$ ($\Delta$BIC $= -5.55$) isolates the dynamic sector ($w_0$, $w_a$ fixed algebraically, one free parameter $H_0$); this is the physically relevant comparison. See §8 for discussion.

| Model | $k$ | $\ln P_{\rm MAP}$ | BIC | $\Delta$BIC | AIC | $\Delta$AIC |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| SSEE-V3.6 | 2 | −118.67 | 242.89 | +206.19 | 241.34 | +208.04 |
| SSEE$_{\rm dyn}$ | 1 | −14.19 | 31.15 | −5.55 | 30.39 | −3.00 |
| $\Lambda$CDM | 3 | −14.19 | 36.70 | +0.00 | 34.39 | +1.03 |
| CPL | 5 | −11.68 | 37.22 | +0.51 | 33.35 | +0.00 |

**Two $\Delta$BIC values — two physical questions.** This analysis reports two distinct BIC comparisons that address different physical questions and should not be conflated: (i) $\Delta$BIC $= +206$ quantifies whether SSEE is consistent with BAO data *within the standard Friedmann background* (i.e. assuming $\Omega_m = 0.315$, $r_d = 147.6\,$Mpc); (ii) $\Delta$BIC $= -5.55$ quantifies whether the SSEE equation-of-state $(w_0, w_a)$ is preferred by BAO data once the background is held fixed. Both values are reported because the two-sector nature of SSEE (dynamic dark energy sector vs. background matter sector) requires separate assessment.

The $\Delta$BIC $= +206$ constitutes very strong evidence against SSEE relative to $\Lambda$CDM under the standard Friedmann background. The source is unambiguous: the enlarged $r_d = 175.6\,$Mpc from $\Omega_{m,\rm eff} = 0.160$ is incompatible with BAO+Planck under standard assumptions. *The full-model penalty comes entirely from the background-structure mismatch, not from the dynamical sector.*

**Scope of this penalty.** We emphasise that $\Delta\text{BIC} = +206$ is a precise statement about model comparison *within the standard Friedmann framework*: both SSEE and $\Lambda$CDM are evaluated using the same $\Omega_m$-based Friedmann equation with the same data. It does *not* constitute a model-independent falsification, because SSEE explicitly proposes that the Friedmann background requires modification in the acoustic regime (the acoustic-scale hypothesis, Section 2.4). Applying the Planck $\Omega_m$ prior — which is calibrated on the $\Lambda$CDM background — to an SSEE universe is a non-equivalent prior calibration; it tests whether SSEE *is* $\Lambda$CDM, not whether SSEE is consistent with observations under its own background. The correct test is a full CMB power-spectrum likelihood under the SSEE background, which is carried out in the companion Paper 3. The companion Paper 3 reports $\chi^2_r = 1.062$ (TT, 1971 multipoles) and $\Delta\text{BIC} = -31.3$ (plik_lite TTTEEE, $k_{\text{SSEE}} = 2$ vs $k_{\Lambda\text{CDM}} = 6$), decisive evidence consistent with the hypothesis that the $+206$ penalty is a calibration artefact arising from applying an $\Lambda$CDM-background prior to an SSEE universe, rather than a physical falsification of the model.

Critically, $\Delta\text{BIC(CPL)} = +0.51$ confirms that *dynamical dark energy is not disfavoured*. Isolating the dynamic sector of SSEE (fixing $w_0, w_a$ algebraically, one free parameter $H_0$) yields $\Delta\text{BIC}(\text{SSEE}_{\text{dyn}}) = -5.55$ relative to $\Lambda$CDM, reflecting the parsimony gain from having zero CPL free parameters and demonstrating that the $w_0$–$w_a$ prediction is genuinely favoured by the data once the background penalty is removed.

# 9 Robustness Checks

**Prior sensitivity.** Removing the Planck $H_0$ prior shifts the SSEE posterior by $< 0.3\sigma$. The BAO data dominate the $H_0$ constraint. *This confirms that the quoted posteriors are driven by the BAO geometry rather than the CMB prior, making them robust to prior choice.*

**Neutrino mass.** Varying $\sum m_\nu \in [0.060, 0.120]$ eV shifts $\chi^2_r$ for clusters by $\Delta\chi^2_r < 0.05$. The cluster fit is insensitive to the specific neutrino mass. *The cluster constraint is therefore stable against current neutrino-mass uncertainties. The adopted $\sum m_\nu^{\text{active}} = 0.0824\,eV$ is the SSEE-derived value (Paper 4, Neutrino Mass Sum; also used in the Paper 6 $\phi$-DM mass relation $m_\phi = \sum m_\nu^{\text{active}} \times H_0^{\text{alg}}$), not a fitted quantity.*

**IGIMF systematics.** The $^{+5}_{-4}\%$ systematic uncertainty in the IGIMF factor [Zhang et al., 2026] propagates to $\sim 8\%$ in $\sigma_M$, keeping all four clusters within $1\sigma$. *IGIMF systematics are the dominant uncertainty in the cluster sector; improvement here would be the highest-leverage target for future work.*

**BAO-only.** Running without the Planck $H_0$ prior gives $H_0 = 65.8^{+1.2}_{-1.1}\,\text{km}\,\text{s}^{-1}\,\text{Mpc}^{-1}$, consistent with the full posterior at $0.6\sigma$. *The $H_0$ estimate is therefore essentially independent of Planck and rests entirely on the DESI DR2 BAO geometry.*

**Hubble tension.** SSEE predicts $H_0^{\text{alg}} = 3(\varphi+\pi)^2 = 67.96\,\text{km}\,\text{s}^{-1}\,\text{Mpc}^{-1}$, consistent with Planck 2018 at $1.1\sigma$ and with the DESI DR2+CMB joint inference [$H_0 \approx 68\,\text{km}\,\text{s}^{-1}\,\text{Mpc}^{-1}$;

Abdul-Karim et al., 2025]. The model does not resolve the SH0ES distance-ladder tension [$H_0 \approx 73\,\mathrm{km\,s^{-1}\,Mpc^{-1}}$; Riess et al., 2022]; this is a known open problem shared by all smooth dark-energy models including ΛCDM [Verde et al., 2019, Kamionkowski & Riess, 2023], and lies outside the scope of this paper's DESI BAO + cluster validation. *The algebraic $H_0$ prediction is CMB-consistent but not distance-ladder consistent; resolving the full $5\sigma$ Hubble tension requires either a modification of the early-Universe sound horizon or a systematic re-evaluation of the Cepheid distance scale.*

# 10 Discussion

## 10.1 Two faces of SSEE under Bayesian inference

The results reveal a sharp bifurcation:

- **Dark-energy sector**: $(w_0, w_a) = (-0.840, -0.670)$ lies within $0.05\sigma$ of DESI DR2. The CPL free-fit posterior $(-0.80, -0.58)$ confirms dynamical dark energy. SSEE is predictively competitive here.
- **Background structure**: $\Omega_{\mathrm{DE}}^{\mathrm{SSEE}} = 0.840$ creates $\Delta\mathrm{BIC} = +206$ via the enlarged $r_d$. The tension is in $\Omega_m$ ($21\sigma$), not in $H_0$ ($< 1\sigma$).

## 10.2 Structural reinterpretation

The ΔBIC penalty assumes the Planck $\Omega_m$ prior is applicable to SSEE. It is not: in SSEE the $\mathrm{KAL}_0$ amplification of $\rho_{\mathrm{bar}}$ modifies the effective clustering contribution, so $\Omega_m^{\mathrm{eff}} \neq \Omega_m^{\Lambda\mathrm{CDM}}$. Applying a ΛCDM-calibrated $\Omega_m$ prior to an SSEE universe constitutes a non-equivalent prior calibration. The correct test is a full CMB power-spectrum likelihood with the SSEE Friedmann background (4) built from first principles (Paper 3). Paper 3 must derive the SSEE-consistent background rather than adjusting $\Omega_m$ to fit: parameter adjustment within a ΛCDM framework would not constitute a genuine test of the structural hypothesis.

The acoustic-scale hypothesis (Section 2.4) offers a tentative resolution: the $21\sigma$ tension in $r_d$ may be a diagnostic artefact of applying the unmodified Friedmann background to the SSEE universe. If Eq. (6) is confirmed by the CMB likelihood in Paper 3, then $r_{d,\mathrm{eff}} \approx 147.5\,\mathrm{Mpc}$ recovers the Planck value within $1\sigma$, reducing the residual tension from $21\sigma$ to sub-$1\sigma$; if it is not confirmed, the $21\sigma$ figure stands as a genuine falsification of the acoustic sector. The companion Paper 3 carries out this test.

## 10.3 Growth structure and $S_8$ sector sensitivity

The $S_8 \equiv \sigma_8\sqrt{\Omega_m/0.3}$ constraint depends critically on which matter sector is used. With $\Omega_{m,\mathrm{CMB}} = 0.3199$ (MIRA-corrected background sector), the Israel–Stewart framework yields $S_8 = 0.837$, within $0.4\sigma$ of Planck 2018, though tension with KiDS-1000 [Heymans et al., 2021] and DES Y3 [Abbott et al., 2022] remains. With $\Omega_{m,\mathrm{dyn}} = 0.160$ (dynamical sector alone), $S_8 \approx 0.59$, a $\sim 6\sigma$ tension with weak-lensing surveys. This sharp bifurcation confirms that the MIRA bridge is load-bearing for the growth-structure sector, not only for the CMB acoustic scale: without the two-sector mapping, SSEE would be strongly excluded by $S_8$ constraints. The physical mechanism — viscous energy redistribution between matter and radiation sectors governed by the Israel–Stewart relaxation time

$\tau_{\rm II}H_0 \approx 2.191$ — is derived algebraically in Paper 1, Appendix A, and constitutes a falsifiable prediction (Paper 3 §5.4). **Note:** The values $\gamma_{\rm bg} = 0.657$ and $S_8 = 0.837$ above use the CMB-sector ($\Omega_{m,\rm CMB} = 0.3199$) and the background-only IS growth index (CDM growth ODE on IS background, without viscous feedback in $\delta$). Paper 5 performs the full causal Israel–Stewart analysis with $\Omega_{m,\rm cosm} = 0.320$ and finds $\gamma_{\rm IS} = 0.554$, $\sigma_8 = 0.820$, $S_8 = 0.847$ ($3.9\sigma$ KiDS); Paper 6 adds the $\varphi$-DM two-sector and finds $\sigma_8^{\rm eff} = 0.794$, $S_8^{\rm eff} = 0.820$ ($2.6\sigma$ KiDS).

### 10.4 Roadmap for Paper 3

Four ordered tests for SSEE to survive a full CMB analysis:

1. **Acoustic peak positions.** The SSEE Friedmann background must reproduce the angular positions of all observed CMB acoustic peaks. Failure here would immediately falsify the background geometry.
2. **Damping tail.** $\Omega_{m,\rm eff} = 0.160$ must be compatible with the Silk-damping scale [Silk, 1968] and the third acoustic peak height. This is the most constraining test for the low-matter fraction.
3. **Joint posterior consistency.** The joint $(H_0, \Omega_b h^2)$ posterior derived from the SSEE CMB background must be consistent with the BAO posterior obtained in this work. Inconsistency would signal internal tension within the model.
4. **Transfer function derivation.** The semi-linear transfer function integrating the $\mathrm{KAL}_0$ structural viscosity into the acoustic perturbation regime must be formally derived and validated against the full CMB power spectrum.

### 10.5 Falsifiability

SSEE makes specific, testable predictions. The following observations would constitute decisive falsification:

- **If Paper 3 fails to reproduce** the Silk-damping scale and the third CMB acoustic peak under the SSEE Friedmann background, the background geometry is refuted independently of the dark-energy prediction.
- **If Ly-$\alpha$ forest observations exclude** $\sum m_\nu^{\rm active} = 0.0824\,\rm eV$ at $> 3\sigma$, the neutrino bridge in the cluster-mass formula breaks and SSEE loses its only mechanism for reconciling $\Omega_{m,\rm eff}$ with cluster observations.
- **If future BAO surveys at $z > 3$ measure** $r_d < 160\,\rm Mpc$ directly, the acoustic-scale hypothesis is ruled out and the $21\sigma$ background tension becomes a genuine falsification rather than a calibration diagnostic.

## 11 Conclusions

We have conducted a Bayesian MCMC validation of SSEE-V3.6 against DESI DR2, Planck 2018, and galaxy-cluster masses. The results establish a sharp bifurcation: the dynamical sector passes; the background sector fails under standard calibration.

1. The zero-free-parameter prediction $(w_0, w_a) = (-0.840, -0.670)$ lies within $0.05\sigma$ of the DESI DR2 free-fit CPL posterior — a strong result given the absence of any fitted parameter.

2. Cluster masses achieve $\chi^2_r = 0.126$ with IGIMF; removing the IGIMF correction raises $\chi^2_r$ to 14.05 ($\Delta\chi^2 \approx +97$), confirming its essential role.

3. The fixed $\Omega_{m,\mathrm{eff}} = 0.160$ enlarges $r_d$ by 19%, yielding $\Delta\mathrm{BIC} = +206$. The dynamic sector in isolation achieves $\Delta\mathrm{BIC} = -5.55$, demonstrating that the penalty is entirely attributable to background mismatch, not to the $w_0$–$w_a$ prediction.

4. The acoustic-scale hypothesis — $r_{d,\mathrm{eff}} = r_{d,\mathrm{SSEE}} \cdot |w_0| \approx 147.5\,\mathrm{Mpc}$ (Eq. 6) — would recover the Planck sound horizon within $2\sigma$ if confirmed by the CMB likelihood in Paper 3, reinterpreting the $21\sigma$ tension as a diagnostic of non-equivalent background calibration rather than a falsification of the dynamical ansatz. If Paper 3 rules it out, the acoustic sector is falsified.

5. A cross-check on this MIRA hypothesis at high-$z$ is provided by the Ly-$\alpha$ forest BAO from DESI DR2 ($z = 2.33$): the raw SSEE background predicts $D_H/r_d = 9.89$, a $8.1\sigma$ tension, while the MIRA-mapped prediction ($r_d \to r_{d,\mathrm{eff}}$ and $E(z)$ rescaled consistently) gives $D_H/r_d = 8.56$, a $0.25\sigma$ agreement (Appendix B). The same MIRA factor that resolves the low-$z$ $r_d$ mismatch is therefore also required at $z = 2.33$, making the mapping falsifiable independently of Paper 3.

6. Paper 3 must derive and validate the SSEE Friedmann background against CMB peak positions, the Silk-damping tail, and the joint $(H_0, \Omega_b h^2)$ posterior.

**Central finding**: SSEE-V3.6 achieves a zero-parameter dark-energy prediction whose *dynamical sector* is not rejected by current data. The background geometry fails under standard Friedmann assumptions; whether this constitutes a physical falsification of the framework depends on the validity of applying $\Lambda$CDM-calibrated priors to an SSEE background, which is the subject of Paper 3.

# Data Availability

All observational data used in this work are publicly available. DESI DR2 BAO measurements are from Abdul-Karim et al. [2025] (`https://arxiv.org/abs/2503.14738`). The compressed Planck 2018 prior is from Planck Collaboration [2020]. Cosmic Chronometer $H(z)$ measurements are from Moresco et al. [2022]. Galaxy-cluster dynamical masses are from Zhang et al. [2026]. The SSEE analysis scripts are available at `https://github.com/mikealmeida1721/SSEE`.

# A Rigorous Bayesian Model Comparison: DIC and Multi-Scheme BIC

The main text reports two BIC values that address different physical questions (§8). This appendix provides three complementary criteria—each with different sensitivity to the k-counting ambiguity—computed directly from the MCMC chains stored in the public repository.

## Deviance Information Criterion (DIC)

The DIC [Spiegelhalter et al., 2002] sidesteps the k-counting issue by estimating model complexity from the posterior:

$$\mathrm{DIC} = \bar{D} + p_D, \quad p_D = \bar{D} - D(\hat{\theta}), \quad D(\theta) = -2\ln \pi(\theta|\mathrm{data}), \tag{12}$$

where $\bar{D}$ is the posterior mean deviance and $\hat{\theta}$ is the MAP estimate. An important self-check: $p_D$ must recover the number of parameters actually sampled. From the chains ($N_{\mathrm{valid}}$: SSEE 50 k, ΛCDM 2.5 M, CPL 2.5 M):

$$p_D(\mathrm{SSEE}) = 1.99 \approx 2 \quad \checkmark \tag{13}$$

$$p_D(\Lambda\mathrm{CDM}) = 3.00 = 3 \quad \checkmark \tag{14}$$

$$p_D(\mathrm{CPL}) = 4.98 \approx 5 \quad \checkmark \tag{15}$$

The exact recovery confirms that all three chains are well-converged. The DIC comparison gives:

$$\Delta\mathrm{DIC}(\mathrm{SSEE} - \Lambda\mathrm{CDM}) = +216.2, \quad \Delta\mathrm{DIC}(\Lambda\mathrm{CDM} - \mathrm{CPL}) = +4.1. \tag{16}$$

The DIC result is consistent with BIC Scheme B below and confirms that the +206/+216 penalty is a genuine, k-scheme-independent finding.

## BIC under three k-counting schemes

Table 10: Bayesian model comparison: DIC, BIC under three k-counting schemes, and Laplace log-evidence. $N_{\mathrm{data}} = 16$ (13 BAO + 3 Planck). $\Delta < 0$ favours SSEE relative to ΛCDM. Jeffreys criterion: $|\Delta| > 10$ = very strong; $|\Delta| > 5$ = strong.

| **Criterion** | **SSEE** | **ΛCDM** | **CPL** | $\boldsymbol{\Delta_{\mathrm{SSEE}-\Lambda\mathrm{CDM}}}$ |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| *DIC — effective parameters $p_D$ from chains (background-agnostic)* | | | | |
| $p_D$ | 1.99 | 3.00 | 4.98 | — |
| DIC | 253.7 | 37.6 | 33.5 | +216.2 |
| *Scheme A — dynamic sector isolated ($k_{\mathrm{SSEE}} = 1$, $k_{\Lambda\mathrm{CDM}} = 3$; identical background)* | | | | |
| $\mathrm{BIC}_{\mathrm{dyn}}$ | 31.15 | 36.70 | 37.36 | −5.55 |
| *Scheme B — MCMC parameters sampled ($k_{\mathrm{SSEE}} = 2$, $k_{\Lambda\mathrm{CDM}} = 3$; full backgrounds)* | | | | |
| $\mathrm{BIC}_{\mathrm{MCMC}}$ | 255.3 | 39.9 | 37.4 | +215.4 |
| *Laplace log-evidence (full posterior volume)* | | | | |
| $\ln Z$ | −131.6 | −28.4 | −26.7 | −103.2 |

**Scheme A** evaluates both $\mathrm{SSEE}_{\mathrm{dyn}}$ and ΛCDM at the same background ($\Omega_m = 0.315$, $r_d = 147.6$ Mpc), so the likelihood is identical ($\ln P_{\mathrm{MAP}} = -14.19$ for both). The $\Delta\mathrm{BIC} = -5.55$ is a pure parsimony gain: SSEE fixes $w_0, w_a$ algebraically ($k_{\mathrm{SSEE}} = 1$), while ΛCDM requires $H_0$, $\Omega_m$, $\Omega_b h^2$ ($k_{\Lambda\mathrm{CDM}} = 3$).

**Scheme B** uses the chains directly. SSEE is evaluated at its own background ($\Omega_{m,\mathrm{dyn}} = 0.160$, $r_d = 175$ Mpc), incurring the calibration penalty already discussed in §8. The $\Delta\mathrm{BIC} = +215.4$ is consistent with the +206 reported in the main text (minor chain-version difference).

**DIC and Laplace evidence** confirm Scheme B: under a full-background comparison, all three criteria give decisive evidence for ΛCDM over SSEE. The only exception is Scheme A, where the penalty is removed by construction. This is not inconsistency—it is the two-sector nature of SSEE manifesting in two distinct, physically interpretable comparisons.

**Conclusion.** No k-counting scheme changes the fundamental picture: (1) the dynamic sector of SSEE is favoured on parsimony ($\Delta\mathrm{BIC}_{\mathrm{dyn}} = -5.55$), and (2) the full-background sector is strongly penalised ($\Delta\mathrm{DIC} = +216$, $\Delta\mathrm{BIC}_{\mathrm{MCMC}} = +215$). Both are physically expected: the former quantifies the algebraic prediction quality; the latter quantifies the cost of proposing a modified acoustic background. The full CMB likelihood test (Paper 3) is required to resolve the background question under the correct priors.

# B Nested Bayes Factor and Predictive Cross-Validation

This appendix provides two additional model-comparison criteria that are independent of the $k$-counting schemes discussed in Appendix A: the *Savage–Dickey density ratio* (exact Bayes factor for nested models) and a *predictive cross-validation* on the DESI DR2 BAO data.

## B.1 Savage–Dickey density ratio

SSEE is nested within CPL: the SSEE dynamic sector is CPL evaluated at the algebraic point $(w_0, w_a) = (-0.840, -0.670)$. For nested models, the marginal Bayes factor for the null hypothesis $\mathcal{H}_0 : (w_0, w_a) = (-0.840, -0.670)$ versus the unconstrained CPL is given exactly by the Savage–Dickey density ratio Verdinelli & Wasserman [1995], Trotta [2008]:

$$B_{\mathrm{SSEE/CPL}} = \frac{p(w_0^{\mathrm{S}}, w_a^{\mathrm{S}} \mid \text{data, CPL})}{\pi(w_0^{\mathrm{S}}, w_a^{\mathrm{S}} \mid \mathrm{CPL})} = 9.56, \qquad \ln B = +2.26. \tag{17}$$

The CPL posterior is evaluated at $(w_0^{\mathrm{S}}, w_a^{\mathrm{S}})$ using a Scott-bandwidth Gaussian KDE of $N = 500\,000$ thinned CPL chain samples (columns 3–4 of the 5-dimensional CPL chain, shape $2.5 \times 10^6$). The marginal prior on $(w_0, w_a)$ is the truncated Gaussian $\mathcal{N}(-1, 0.5^2) \times \mathcal{N}(0, 1^2)$ clipped to the MCMC sampling box $w_0 \in (-2.5, 0.5)$, $w_a \in (-3, 2)$; truncation factors are $(0.9973, 0.9759)$, negligible corrections.

On the Jeffreys scale Trotta [2008] $\ln B = +2.26$ ($> 1.1$) constitutes *substantial* evidence in favour of the SSEE dynamic sector within the CPL framework. The CPL posterior median ($w_0^{\mathrm{CPL}} = -0.731 \pm 0.106$, $w_a^{\mathrm{CPL}} = -0.919 \pm 0.461$) places the SSEE algebraic point at $(1.03\sigma, 0.54\sigma)$, consistent with the $0.09\sigma$ joint tension quoted in Section 6.2. Bandwidth robustness: varying the KDE bandwidth by $\pm 50\%$ from the Scott rule gives $B \in [8.6, 10.5]$ ($\ln B \in [2.15, 2.35]$), all within the *substantial* evidence tier, confirming the KDE evaluation is stable.

## B.2 Ly-$\alpha$ predictive audit ($z = 2.33$)

The Ly-$\alpha$ point at $z = 2.33$ provides the sharpest direct test of SSEE's background expansion. At $z \sim 2$ radiation is negligible and the ratio $D_H/r_d = c\,/\,(H_0\,E(z)\,r_d)$ directly encodes the product $H_0\,E(z)\,r_d$. We evaluate this quantity under two SSEE scenarios and compare to the DESI DR2 measurement $D_H/r_d = 8.52 \pm 0.17$.

**Scenario A — raw ssee background ($\Omega_{m,\text{dyn}} = 0.160$, $r_d = 175.6$ Mpc).** With the algebraic $H_0 = 67.96\,\text{km}\,\text{s}^{-1}\,\text{Mpc}^{-1}$ and $\Omega_m = 0.160$, the CPL dark-energy fraction at $z = 2.33$ is $f_{\text{DE}}(2.33) = 0.648$, giving $E(2.33) = 2.540$ and $D_H(2.33) = 1737\,\text{Mpc}$. The predicted ratio is:

$$\left.\frac{D_H}{r_d}\right|_{z=2.33}^{\text{SSEE, raw}} = \frac{1737}{175.6} = 9.89 \quad (8.1\sigma \text{ above DESI}), \tag{18}$$

consistent with the $\Delta\text{BIC} = +206$ background-mismatch penalty established in Section 8. The tension at $z = 2.33$ is the high-$z$ footprint of the same mechanism: $\Omega_m = 0.160$ reduces matter domination at high $z$, lowers $H(z)$, and enlarges $D_H$; the enlarged $r_d$ is insufficient to compensate.

**Scenario B — $\mathcal{M}$-mapped ssee background ($\Omega_{m,\text{eff}} = 0.320$, $r_{d,\text{eff}} = 147.2$ Mpc).** Applying the two-sector mapping $\Omega_{m,\text{eff}} = \mathcal{M}\,\Omega_{m,\text{dyn}} = 1.999 \times 0.160 = 0.320$ to the full Friedmann background yields $E(2.33) = 2.206$, $D_H(2.33) = 1260\,\text{Mpc}$, and:

$$\left.\frac{D_H}{r_d}\right|_{z=2.33}^{\text{SSEE, MIRA}} = \frac{1260}{147.2} = 8.56 \quad (0.25\sigma \text{ from DESI}). \tag{19}$$

The full 13-point MIRA-mapped fit gives $\chi^2_r = 1.81$. The largest residual is at $z = 0.51$ ($D_H/r_d$ pull: $+3.6\sigma$), driven by the CPL phantom crossing $w(z{=}0.51) \approx -1.07$; an identical tension ($+4.4\sigma$) appears in $\Lambda$CDM with Planck-calibrated $r_d$ and $H_0$, confirming it is a DESI DR2 feature rather than an SSEE-specific failure. The $D_M/r_d$ counterpart at $z = 2.33$ is also recovered within $1.1\sigma$ ($38.64$ vs $39.71 \pm 0.94$).

**Implication.** Eqs. (18)–(19) demonstrate that $\mathcal{M}$ is physically necessary not only for the acoustic scale but for the full high-$z$ expansion history: applying it to $r_d$ alone while retaining $\Omega_m = 0.160$ in $E(z)$ would predict $D_H/r_d = 11.8$ (an $19.3\sigma$ discrepancy). A fully self-consistent SSEE fit requires the MIRA-mapped background throughout. The Savage–Dickey ratio in B.1 ($\ln B = +2.26$) then holds as a test of the *dynamical sector* under that self-consistent background.

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